

ARTICLE

Gantt Chart vs. Kanban Board: Which One Should You Use?

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September 12, 2025

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Gantt charts and Kanban boards are two of the most popular project management tools. Both help teams visualize work, track progress, and deliver results, but they serve very different purposes.

In this post, we'll break down the differences between Gantt charts and Kanban boards, show you when to use each (or both together), and share expert best practices for combining them effectively in Smartsheet.

Gantt vs. Kanban

Gantt charts are timeline-based tools that map tasks, dependencies, and milestones, making them best for planning and scheduling. Kanban boards are visual task boards that track work as it moves through stages, making them ideal for managing daily workflows.

- If you need structured timelines → choose Gantt charts
- If you need task-level visibility → choose Kanban boards.

Use both together in Smartsheet to connect long-term planning with real-time execution.

What's the Difference Between Gantt Charts and Kanban Boards?

A **Gantt chart** is a timeline-based project management tool that shows task dependencies, start and end dates, and milestones. It is most commonly used in traditional project management and Waterfall methodologies, where projects follow a linear sequence and deadlines are fixed.

A **Kanban board** is a task board that visualizes workflow stages using cards that move from left to right. It supports Agile, Lean, and Scrum practices by enabling teams to manage work iteratively, optimize flow, and adapt to changing priorities in real time.

Gantt Chart vs. Kanban Board: Comparison Guide

Here’s a quick side-by-side comparison of Gantt vs Kanban, including when to use each and which methodologies they support.

Feature	Gantt Chart	Kanban Board
Best For	Planning timelines & dependencies	Managing daily workflows
Stage of Project	Planning & scheduling	Execution & task tracking
View	Timeline with milestones	Board with task cards
Key Strength	Big-picture roadmap & deadlines	Real-time task visibility
Dependencies	Yes	No
Task Focus	High-level structure	Day-to-day details
Methodology Supported	Waterfall, Traditional PM	Agile, Lean, Scrum

Explore more: [Gantt Chart Guide](#)

Gantt Chart and Kanban Board Similarities

Gantt charts and Kanban boards both allow teams to plan and track work visually. They help you monitor real-time progress, visualize project tasks, and adapt to changes as work evolves. Team members can edit, move, or update tasks to keep projects progressing efficiently.

While they differ in purpose, both tools share core benefits:

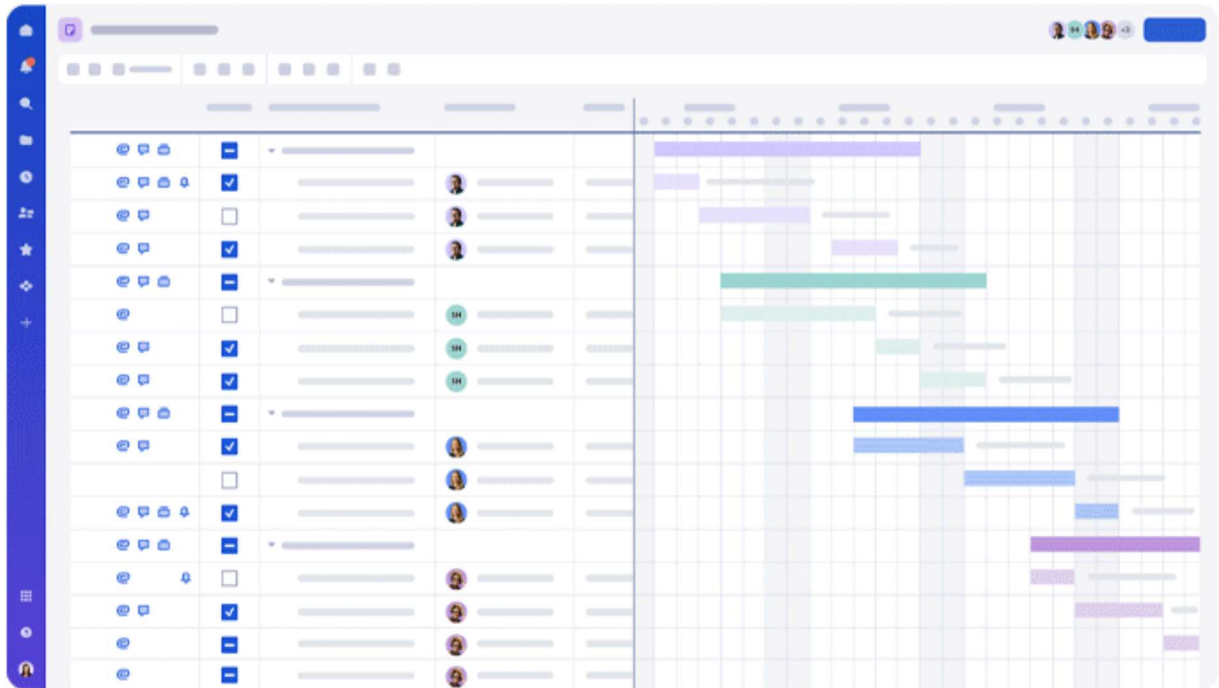
- **Task Visualization:** Both provide a clear, visual map of project work.
- **Real-Time Updates:** Team members can edit tasks and progress instantly.
- **Adaptability:** Work can be shifted, reprioritized, or reassigned as projects evolve.
- **Efficiency:** Both views keep everyone aligned, helping projects stay on track.

When to Combine Kanban and Gantt Charts

Kanban boards and Gantt charts work best together when projects need both strategic scheduling and flexible execution. Common situations include:

- **Cross-team projects like construction or IT rollouts**, where Gantt charts align milestones across departments and Kanban boards keep each team’s daily tasks moving.
- **Complex initiatives like product launches**, where you map out launch dates in a Gantt chart while using Kanban boards to track design, development, and marketing tasks.
- **Agile programs with dependencies**, where shifting tasks on a Kanban board must also update the broader timeline in a Gantt chart.

Smartsheet brings both views together in one platform, so you can manage high-level plans and day-to-day execution without duplication. [Start a free trial today.](https://www.smartsheet.com/try-it?trp=12429&lpv=txtlink1)



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[Monique Odom-Stearn](https://www.linkedin.com/in/moniqueodom-stearn/) (<https://www.linkedin.com/in/moniqueodom-stearn/>), Architecture Solutions Manager at Comcast, says Kanban and Gantt charts are great tools for Scrum meetings or Agile stand-ups. "They're an easy way to get a quick understanding of exactly how your projects are doing and where they're at," she says.

Expert Insight:

"It's particularly effective to use Kanban and Gantt charts together if you have tasks or projects that are dependent on each other, and you need to be able to see how moving things in an Agile environment will affect other tasks."

— Monique Odom-Stearn, Architecture Solutions Manager at Comcast



Smartsheet project management software allows you to [toggle seamlessly between Kanban and Gantt views](#) so teams are always working from the same source of truth.

Best Practices for Using Kanban Alongside Gantt Charts

Best practices for using Kanban boards alongside Gantt charts include syncing the charts, updating both regularly, and leveraging task hierarchy. Leaders should also monitor workflows in both views and use that information to improve day-to-day execution and the overall timeline.

To get the most out of using both views:

1. Keep Both Views Synced

Set up automations so that updates in your Kanban board automatically reflect in your Gantt chart. This eliminates duplication and ensures accuracy.

“Whenever possible, ensure that your Kanban and Gantt charts are either coming from the same data source or are linked through an automation.”

— Monique Odom-Stearn, Comcast

2. Leverage Task Hierarchy

Break projects into clear hierarchies to keep teams focused on the details while enabling leadership to stay aligned with the big picture.

“Broad categories are site survey, facility and security readiness, checks, installations, etc. — broken down into smaller subtasks with start and end dates and the responsible engineer names and contact info. This provides a detailed view for project teams managing day-to-day operations while allowing managers to see a high-level summary.”

— [Ipshita Mukherjee](https://www.linkedin.com/in/ipshita-mukherjee-38601845/overlay/about-this-profile/) (https://www.linkedin.com/in/ipshita-mukherjee-38601845/overlay/about-this-profile/), Senior Technical Project Manager, Verizon

Use Gantt charts to map out larger tasks and high-level summaries and Kanban for tracking the smaller tasks and day-to-day operations.

3. Monitor Bottlenecks and Feedback

Compare Kanban bottlenecks with Gantt delays to spot workflow issues early and adjust both short-term execution and long-term planning.

Explore more: [Gantt Chart Templates](#)

How Smartsheet Brings Gantt and Kanban Together

In Smartsheet, you don't have to choose one or the other. With a single project sheet, you can:

- View tasks as a Kanban board with drag-and-drop cards.
- Switch to a Gantt chart with dependencies, milestones, and timelines.
- Keep both synced automatically for real-time updates.
- Plan timelines, manage tasks, and keep your entire team aligned in one platform.

[Try Smartsheet free for 30 days](#)

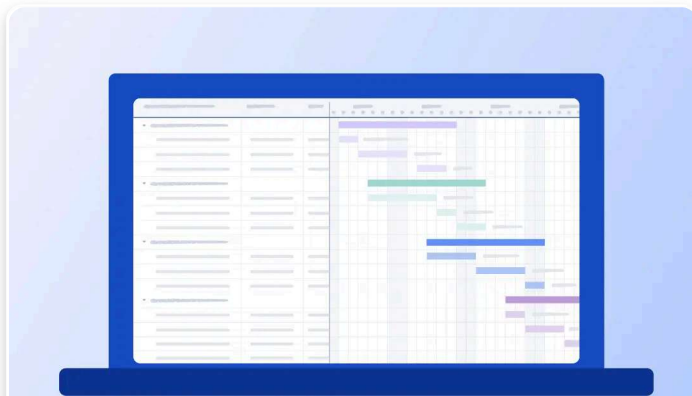
Final Takeaway

- **Use Gantt charts** for planning and big-picture scheduling.
- **Use Kanban boards** for daily task management.
- **Use both together** in Smartsheet to keep teams aligned from high-level strategy to day-to-day execution.

The Smartsheet AI-powered platform revolutionizes how you manage projects, portfolios, and processes, empowering organizations to innovate, collaborate, and achieve results at scale with enterprise-grade security.



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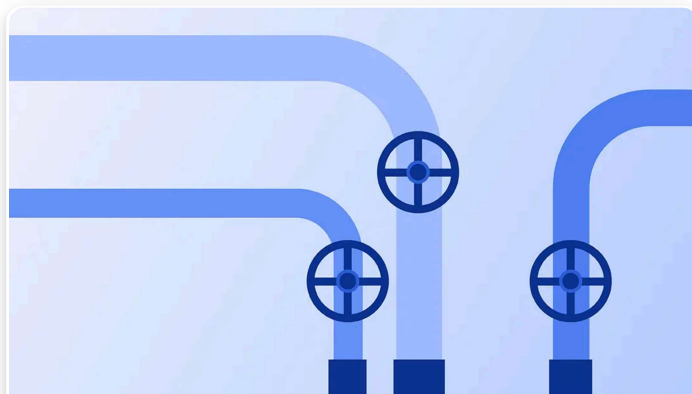
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How to Create a Gantt Chart in Smartsheet

Learn how to make a Gantt chart in Smartsheet with a step-by-step guide & video. Discover the benefits & get started with Smartsheet's Gantt view.



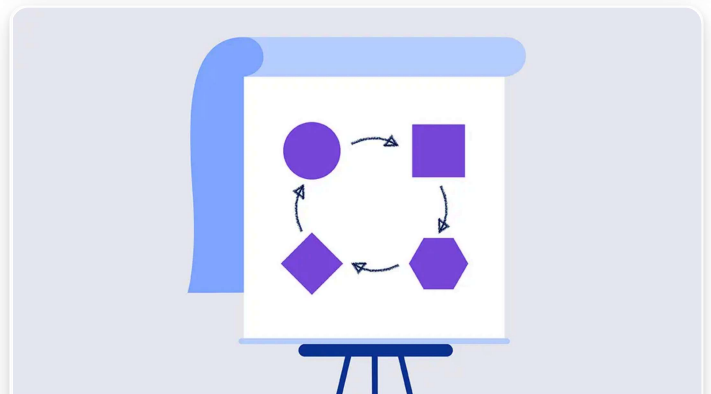
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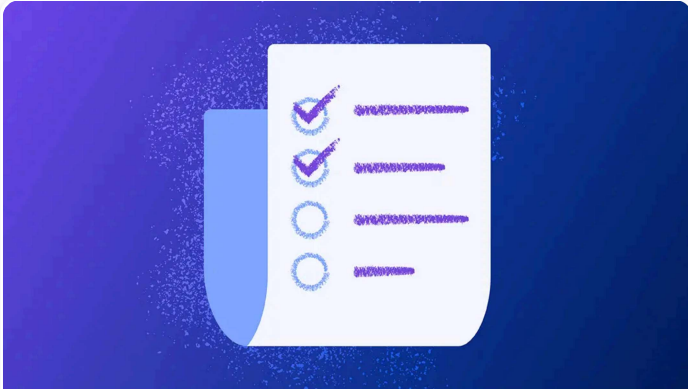
Download free Kanban board templates, and find tips on how using a Kanban board template can benefit you and your team.



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Tips & best practices

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Simplify project management with Smartsheet Gantt charts. Save time by automating updates, sharing progress, and managing dependencies in one place. Try it free today.

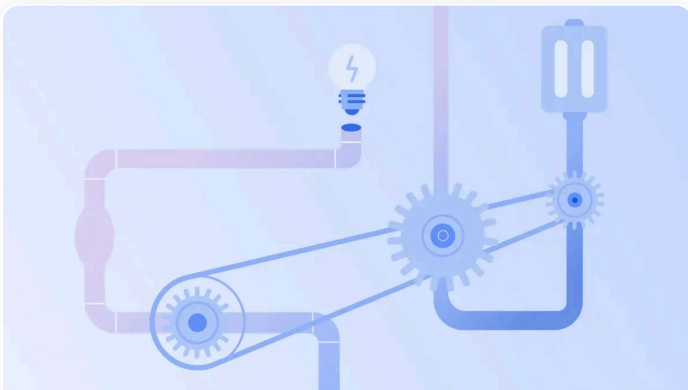


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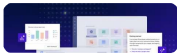
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